

ART

STORMING THE BASTION

The National Gallery in London is showing an original commission by its first contemporary fellow, the Indian artist Nalini Malani







ART FOR THE TIMES Artworks from Nalini Malani's *My Reality Is Different*

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The National Gallery is Britain's most revered art institution along with the equally venerable Royal Academy. For many decades, these were the two pillars of the British establishment's conception of great art. Even as all sorts of modern art movements swirled around them, the 'National' and the 'Academy' stayed grimly besieged, sticking to their guns of the large portraits and Biblical set-pieces and so on. For the longest time, the most modern and radical painter either pile displayed was one Joseph Mallord William Turner, and not because they recognised his radicalism but because they loved his classicism.

Over the last 60-70 years, this has changed. The RA was the first to start admitting contemporary art. The National Gallery and the National Portrait Gallery have become less fuddy-duddy over the last 30 years, recognising the need to stay relevant to succeeding generations of visitors. It is clearly with this outreach that the NG has begun its Contemporary Fellowship with Art Fund. Nalini Malani is the first person to receive this fellowship.

Going into the museum, you walk up the central flight of steps and through the room with the life-size portraits to reach the 'Malani Room'. There, one of the big halls with its high ceilings has been turned into a darkened space. As your eyes adjust, you find yourself immersed in images and animations projected on all four walls. The projections are at such height that you have no choice but to sit down on the floor and look up at this planetarium of constantly shifting image constellations.

The terms of the Fellowship seem to ask the eminent artist to engage with the collection at the National as well as one other collection in the UK, and Malani has chosen her material from the paintings in London as well as ones at the Holburne Museum in Bath. As the images cascade around you, cut up, slanted, inverted, you recognise some of the famous paintings you've seen; under and over these images are sketches, scrawls, re-workings in Malani's own amazing hand. The accompanying soundtrack is space-agey and one-geared, and the weakest part of this fantastic work. For a while I put on my sound-cancelling headphones and was happier swimming in the music of the imagery.

> Over the past 30 years, the National Gallery has recognised the need to stay relevant to the new generation of visitors

In leading you into re-examining the old white master painters, Malani turns Turner on his head: where you sometimes suspect the cantankerous 19th-century master used western classical themes as vehicles for his wondrous painterly abstractions, Malani takes as a frame her half-a-century-plus of exploration in the late-modern and post-modern and uses that to work a complex *riyaaz* (in the sense of constructive repetition) of the Occidental greats, and through that she gets us into thinking about our own time and its relentless tsunami of fractured pictures. ■

Ruchir Joshi

(Nalini Malani's My Reality Is Different *is showing at the National Gallery, London, till June 11)*